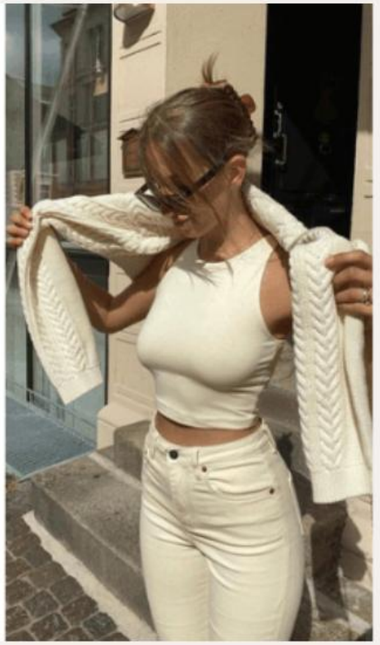


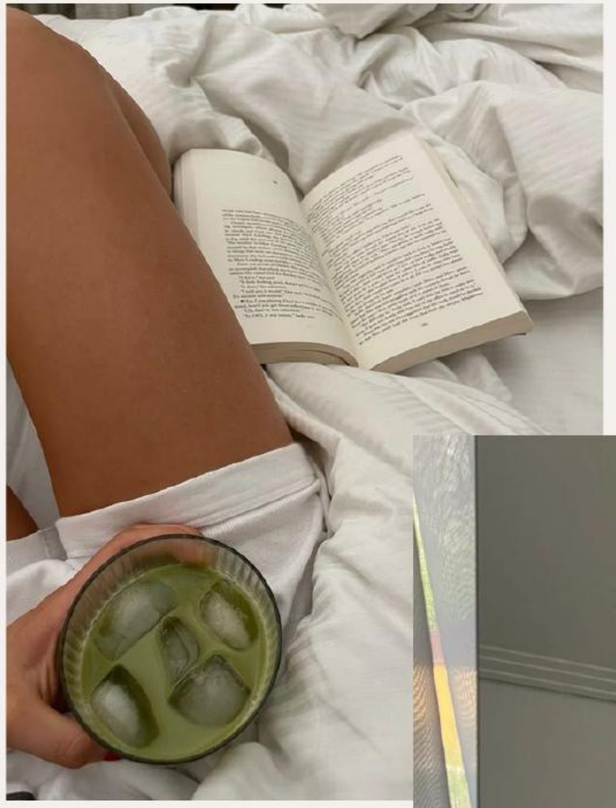
That Girl™

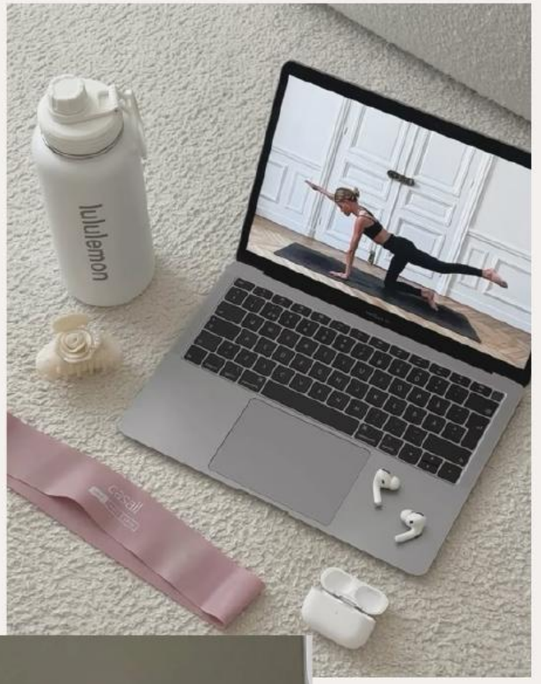
A zine about aesthetic discipline, wellness myths, and the culture that teaches girls to perfect themselves

Susan Su and Zyde Javier

What Is “That Girl”?

She wakes up before the sun rises. She drinks green smoothies, journals in a soft linen notebook, and moves through her day with a serene glow. “That girl” is the idealized version of feminine order and wellness that TikTok asks young women to imitate—pretty, productive, and always in control.







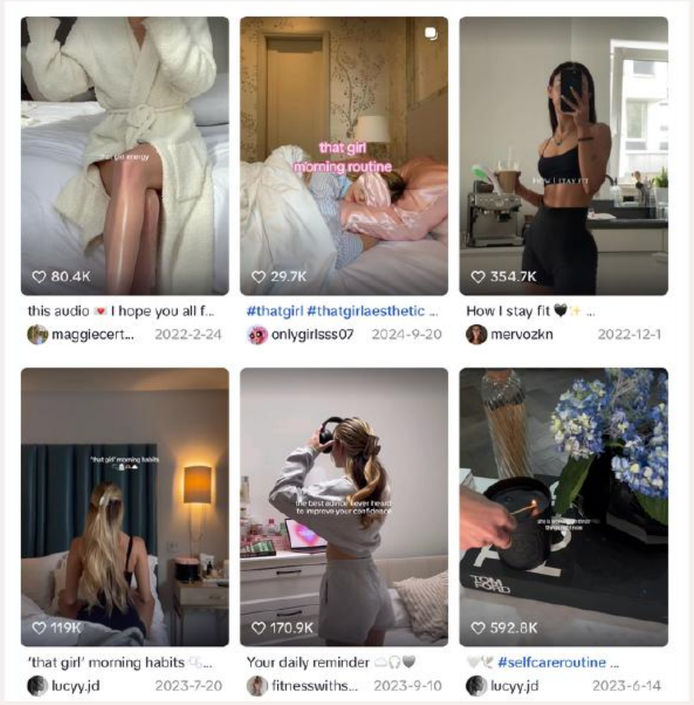
“5:00 AM: the grind starts early”

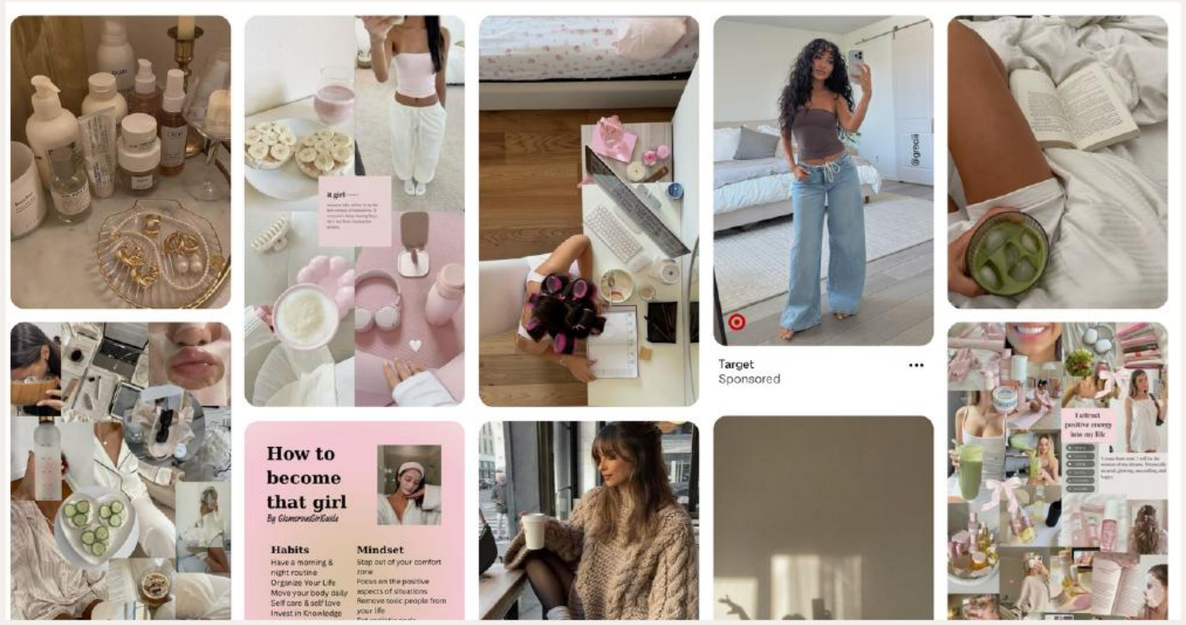
“Perfect morning, perfect girl”

“Clean space, clean mind, clean you”

Why This Is Popular Culture

According to Fiske, popular culture is what is **accessible, trendy, emotionally charged**, and widely shared. The “that girl” trend checks every box: it’s easy to copy, instantly recognizable, deeply aspirational, and endlessly reproduced through TikTok’s algorithm.





“Popular culture is made by the people, not imposed upon them; it stems from within, from below, not from above. Popular culture is the art of making do with what the system provides” (Fiske 21)

A trend becomes a culture when millions repeat it

Desire spreads faster than information

Why It Matters



“That girl” isn’t just a TikTok routine. It’s a script for how young women should live, look, and behave. It shapes our understanding of wellness, beauty, and feminine worth. If we don’t question it, it becomes the silent standard for womanhood.



“The desire to be oneself does not mean the desire to be fundamentally different, but rather to situate individual differences within communal allegiances” (Fiske 10)

The Aesthetic, Style=Attitude

The “that girl” look is not accidental, it's a **carefully curated visual language**. Soft lighting, neutral tones, clean white kitchens, and symmetrical layouts create a mood of perfect order. The aesthetic is calm, but the effort behind it is anything but.





Burke argues that style is “a dancing of an attitude,” meaning aesthetic choices express values. The “that girl” aesthetic communicates an **attitude** of control, discipline, and moral purity. It tells us not just how to live, but **how to be**.

“Men seek for vocabularies that are reflections of reality. To this end, they must develop vocabularies that are selections of reality. And any selection of reality must, in certain circumstances, function as a deflection of reality” (Burke 59)

Persuading Through Vibes

The aesthetic persuades without speaking. It convinces viewers that beauty is found in discipline, that serenity can be bought, and that wellness is a performance you can display on your page. Vibes become a form of moral advice.

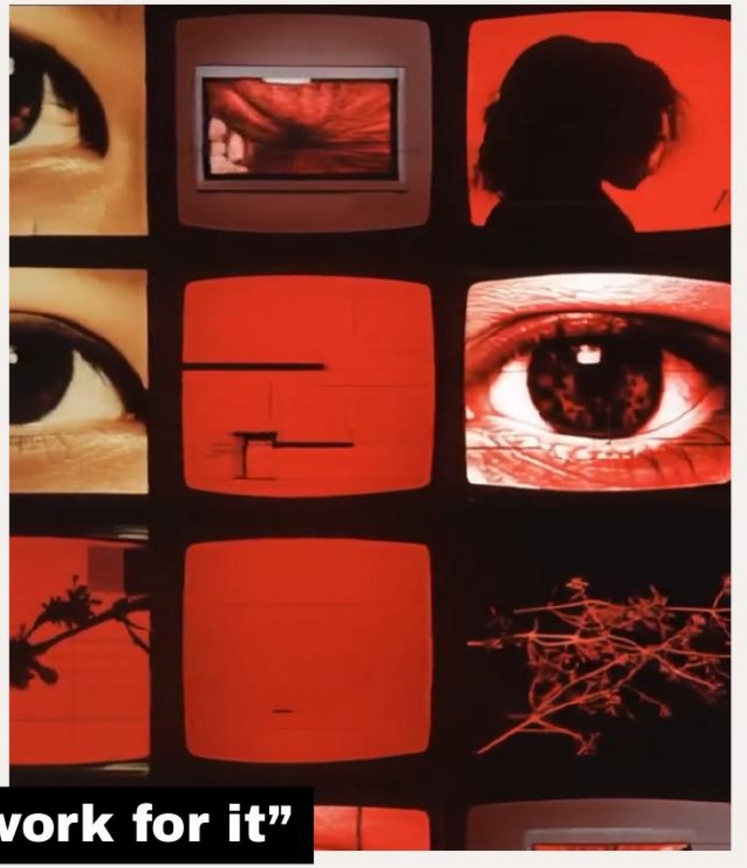
“Vibes = Values”





“Aesthetic becomes aspiration”

The Call to Become “Her”: Ideology and Interpellation



Althusser explains that ideology works by calling out to individuals and telling them who they are, transforming them into subjects who willingly take up the identity being offered. It positions viewers as subjects who internalize the routine, the discipline, and the aesthetic as markers of who they should be.



“Here’s your sign to start”

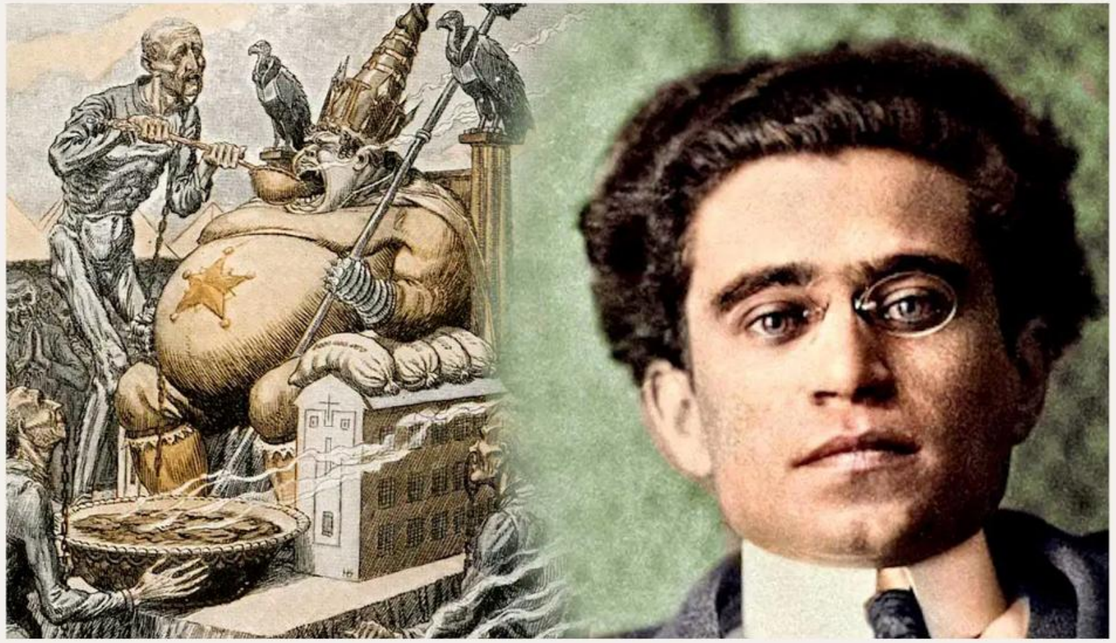
“You can’t be her unless you work for it”

The captions in “that girl” videos speak directly to the viewer: “You can start today.” “Become the best version of you.” This direct address does more than motivate; it hails the viewer into a specific feminine role.

“...I only wish to point out that you and I are always already subjects, and as such constantly practice the rituals of ideological recognition, which guarantee for us that we are indeed concrete, individual, distinguishable and (naturally) irreplaceable subjects” (Althusser 85)

What Feels Like “Common Sense”

Gramsci calls **hegemony** the process by which certain values come to feel “**natural**”. The “that girl” trend makes it feel normal, expected even, that women should wake early, be thin, be productive, look clean, and display their lives aesthetically.







“Thin = Healthy”

“Clean = Disciplined”

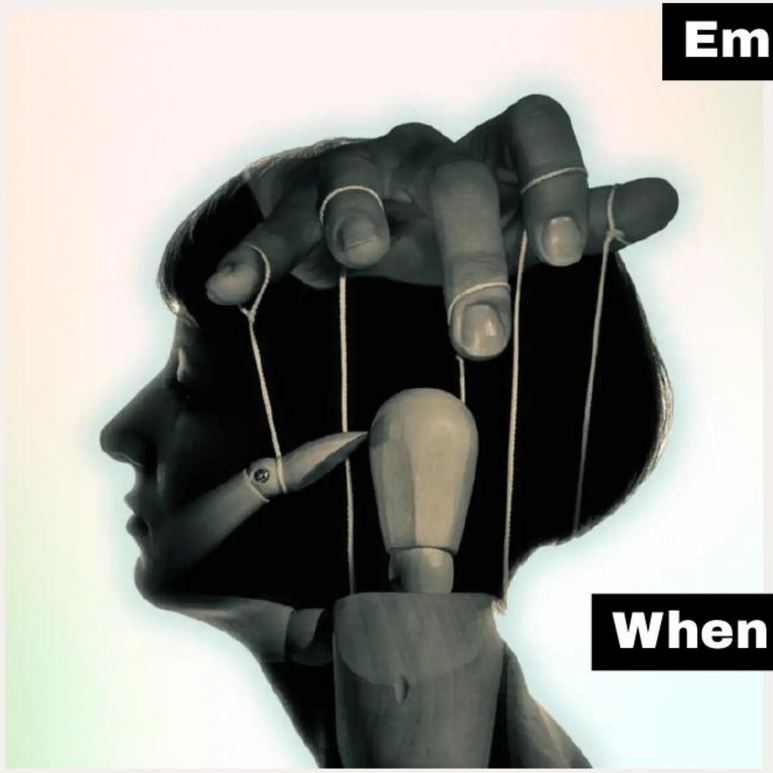
“Productive = Good”

“Hegemony is not a static entity; it is marked by a series of changing discourses and practices intrinsically bound up with social power” (Barker 68)

How Power Masks Itself

The beauty of “that girl” is also its danger: it hides discipline inside the language of empowerment. It tells women that they are choosing this life, when really the culture has chosen it for them. When control feels like freedom, hegemony has done its work.





Empowerment or obedience?



When power feels natural, it’s winning.

“Hegemony is the ‘spontaneous’ consent of the masses to the direction imposed on social life by the dominant group” (Gramsci 12)

Connotation → Truth and The Wellness Myth

Barthes warns that repeated images can turn cultural values into “common sense.” In the “that girl” trend, the connotations of thinness, order, and cleanliness become redefined as the literal meaning of “wellness”. The myth of wellness tells us that if we fix our routines, bodies, and aesthetics, we will fix our lives. This allows myth to simplify worldly ideas to make ideology comfortable. However, it also hides how deeply these expectations are tied to class privilege, gender norms, and consumption.



“This is why myth is experienced as innocent speech: not because its intentions are hidden – if they were hidden, they could not be efficacious – but because they are naturalized.”(Barthe 130)





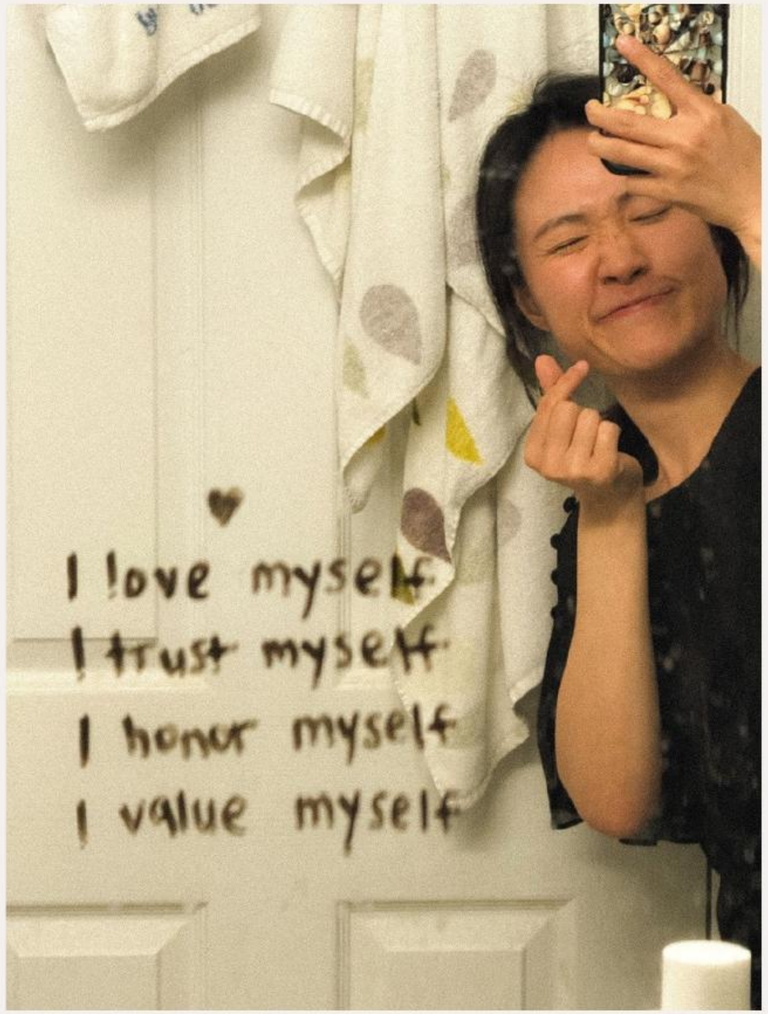
These are not truths. These are connotations pretending to be truths.

What Real Wellness Looks Like

What if wellness didn't require perfection? What if rest, pleasure, and community mattered more than discipline? Real care is messy, flexible, and personal—not aesthetic.



Becoming "that girl" is not liberation. It's another version of the feminine ideal dressed in beige. True empowerment begins when we stop performing and start existing when we choose ourselves, not the algorithm.



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